The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

31st January 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Impermissible (अस्वीकार्य)

Meaning: Not allowed or permitted.
Synonyms: Prohibited, unacceptable, inadmissible
Antonyms: Permissible, acceptable, allowable
Example: The court ruled that discrimination based on gender is impermissible in any form.

2. Setback (नुकसान /झटका)

Meaning: A reversal or slowing down of progress.
Synonyms: Hindrance, obstacle, delay
Antonyms: Progress, advancement, success
Example: The company faced a major setback when their product failed safety tests.

VOCABULARY

3. Rescind (रद्द करना)

Meaning: To revoke, cancel, or repeal a law, order, or agreement.
Synonyms: Revoke, repeal, annul
Antonyms: Enforce, implement, uphold
Example: The government decided to rescind the controversial law after massive protests.

4. Jeopardy (खतरा)

Meaning: Danger of loss, harm, or failure.
Synonyms: Risk, peril, hazard
Antonyms: Safety, security, protection
Example: The soldier's life was in jeopardy during the fierce battle.

VOCABULARY

5. Supplant (बदलना/हटाना)

Meaning: To replace or take the place of someone or something.
Synonyms: Replace, supersede, overthrow
Antonyms: Retain, maintain, uphold
Example: The new software is designed to supplant the outdated system.

6. Recalibrate (पुनः समायोजित करना)

Meaning: To adjust or correct something in order to improve accuracy or efficiency.
Synonyms: Readjust, reconfigure, fine-tune
Antonyms: Misadjust, distort, disorganize
Example: The engineers had to recalibrate the machine to ensure precise measurements.

VOCABULARY

7. Laudable (सराहनीय)

Meaning: Deserving praise and commendation.
Synonyms: Admirable, commendable, praiseworthy
Antonyms: Disgraceful, condemnable, blameworthy
Example: Her efforts to clean up the neighborhood were laudable and inspired others to join.

8. Competence (क्षमता)

Meaning: The ability or skill to do something successfully.
Synonyms: Capability, proficiency, skill
Antonyms: Incompetence, inadequacy, inability
Example: The board questioned the competence of the management in handling the crisis.

VOCABULARY

9. Sagacious (विवेकी)

Meaning: Showing keen mental discernment and good judgment; wise.
Synonyms: Wise, insightful, judicious
Antonyms: Foolish, unwise, imprudent
Example: His sagacious decisions helped the company avoid several potential crises.

10. Exacerbate (बिगाड़ना)

Meaning: To make a problem, situation, or negative feeling worse.
Synonyms: Aggravate, worsen, intensify
Antonyms: Alleviate, relieve, ease
Example: Polluted air exacerbates respiratory conditions, especially in crowded cities.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Bring in
Meaning – To introduce or generate (e.g., income, new ideas).

2. Hold up
Meaning – To delay or obstruct.

3. Lash into
Meaning – To criticize or attack forcefully.

4. Own up
Meaning – To confess or admit.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. Wool over the eyes

Meaning - to trick or deceive someone.

2. Jump through hoops

Meaning - to do a complicated things in order to get or achieve something

3. Up in the air

Meaning - (of a plan or issue) still to be settled; unresolved.

VOCABULARY

4. By the book

Meaning - exactly according to the rules.

5. To get down to business

Meaning - to start the work that has to be done.

Article for Reading

More and better: On India’s educational infrastructure

The Supreme Court of India's ruling that there can be no reservation based on residence in admission to PG medical courses is consistent with the constitutional mandate of equality before law, but may adversely affect the priorities and health-care requirements of the States. The Court has reminded everyone that there is only one 'domicile' for Indians, and that the right to seek admissions anywhere in the country must be open to residents of all States. This is in line with a series of verdicts on the question whether there can be admissions based on institutional preference or residential requirements. The view is that institutional preference, that is choosing candidates who had passed out of an institution for admission to PG courses in the same institution, is constitutionally permissible; and that admission to UG medical courses can have a residential requirement, primarily because the basic medical needs of a region can be better addressed by admitting more people from the same background so that doctors emerging from the system would render public service there.

However, on the principle that higher qualifications brook no compromise with merit, the prevailing view is that PG courses should not be open for any such residential preference, as the need to attract the best talent is higher. Many States do fill up PG seats in government medical colleges, and seats available to them in private colleges, barring those that are filled on an all-India basis, with candidates drawn from their own States. Candidates from other States can enter PG medical courses in a State only through the national quota. This system, now impermissible, has its own justification, as PG students form the backbone of medical services in government hospitals. In addition, such students have the additional incentive of joining government service and, thereby, acquiring eligibility to apply for PG courses as 'service candidates'. The southern States, in particular, have invested heavily in medical education, establishing a college in almost every district.

These would like to accommodate more candidates from their States to keep their medical services going and with an eye on future manpower needs. It is expected that aggrieved States may seek a review of this judgment. It is likely that the verdict will result in the Union government finding one more way to restrict the role of the States in medical admissions. Interestingly, the distinction the Court has made between PG and UG courses when it comes to prioritising local needs may be a sound argument in itself for questioning the continuing tendency to centralise even UG admissions across streams. The solution lies in creating educational infrastructure of near-uniform quality in every district.

Summary

The Supreme Court of India has ruled that States cannot reserve seats in PG medical courses based on residence, reinforcing the constitutional principle of equality before law. The Court emphasized that Indians have only one domicile and should have the right to seek admission anywhere in the country. While institutional preference and residential quotas are allowed for UG courses to meet regional healthcare needs, PG admissions must prioritize merit. Many States, especially in the South, have relied on local candidates for PG seats to sustain their government hospitals and ensure a steady medical workforce. The verdict could limit State control over medical admissions, potentially prompting a review plea. It also raises concerns about the increasing centralization of medical education, suggesting that the long-term solution lies in improving educational infrastructure uniformly across all districts.

Tone:

The tone is analytical and formal. It presents a balanced view, acknowledging the constitutional rationale behind the verdict while also highlighting its potential impact on State healthcare systems and medical education policy.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
Which of the following best describes the Supreme Court's stance on institutional preference and residential requirements?

a) Both are unconstitutional at all levels of medical education.
b) Institutional preference is allowed in UG admissions but not in PG admissions.
c) Residential preference is permitted in UG courses but not in PG courses.
d) Both institutional and residential preferences are allowed for PG courses.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
What concern does the passage express regarding the Supreme Court's ruling?

a) It may lead to a decline in the quality of medical education.
b) It could weaken the autonomy of States in managing medical admissions.
c) It will increase regional disparities in healthcare access.
d) It will discourage students from taking up medical education.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
What broader issue does the passage suggest in the context of medical education?

a) The excessive involvement of private institutions in medical training.
b) The shortage of PG seats in government medical colleges.
c) The over-centralization of healthcare policy in India.
d) The lack of uniform quality in medical education across regions.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

Unclear agenda: On Donald Trump and his policy agenda

The policy agenda of U.S. President Donald Trump suffered a political setback when a controversial memo issued by his administration's Office of Management and Budget (OMB), proposing to freeze federal funds for a range of social services was blocked by a District Court judge. In the wake of confusion and chaos regarding which programmes would be impacted, the White House rescinded the memo, a forced act of back-pedalling. Federal grants and loans worth trillions of dollars were potentially shut off for health-care initiatives for millions of low-income Americans — including within the Medicaid system — earlier this week when the OMB memo was apparently published "without vetting by key officials in the White House". It appeared that funds for schools, hospitals and shelters were also in jeopardy, in most cases policies that would have assisted vulnerable groups.

The administration has now clarified that benefits such as the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Programme and student loans would not be affected by the freeze — nor would Medicare, Medicaid and Social Security payments and funds for small business, farmers, Pell grants, Head Start, rental assistance, and similar programmes. Despite the backdown, the Trump administration reiterated that it would not, at a broader level, compromise on the President's commitment to review and recalibrate federal funding allocations towards cutting down on government waste and unrequired regulations. White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said on social media, "This is NOT a rescission of the federal funding freeze. It is simply a rescission of the memo". While there was little doubt that Mr. Trump would, during his second term, seek to slash public expenditure on certain social services, the ad hoc and apparently uncoordinated approach towards this cut left many, including some Republicans, baffled.

The OMB memo also raised the spectre of Mr. Trump's fiat by executive orders seeking to supplant the traditional role of Congress, which is the prime vector for appropriations and earmarking funds for specific projects across sectors. This is a precarious path to follow, and it is likely to face further pushback from Congressional lawmakers if it continues. There is also concern that Mr. Trump has surrounded himself with acolytes who subscribe to the ideas in the so-called 'Project 2025', which some regard as a right-wing agenda that could prove to be more divisive than it is capable of genuinely addressing urgent political priorities. While Mr. Trump may have become more adept at personnel management, it is equally important that he does not exacerbate the bitter polarisation of the American polity over the coming four years.

Question 4:
What does the passage imply about Trump's reliance on individuals aligned with 'Project 2025'?

a) It may lead to the promotion of a strongly right-wing policy agenda.
b) It will ensure a more balanced approach to governance.
c) It will primarily focus on economic reforms rather than social policies.
d) It signals a shift towards a more centrist ideology.
e) None of the above

Question 5:
Why did some Republicans find the Trump administration's approach to cutting social services funding baffling?

a) The administration failed to propose any alternative welfare programs.
b) The funding cuts were too small to make any significant impact.
c) The approach appeared uncoordinated and lacked clear strategy.
d) The administration prioritized corporate tax cuts over social spending cuts.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question:

Original Text

Stagflation is an economic condition characterized by stagnant economic growth, high inflation, and rising unemployment. It presents a unique challenge for policymakers because traditional economic tools that address inflation or unemployment separately may not work effectively when both issues occur simultaneously. The term gained prominence in the 1970s when many economies, particularly the United States, experienced slow growth and high inflation due to oil price shocks and monetary policy failures. The primary causes of stagflation include supply-side shocks, such as rising commodity prices or supply chain disruptions, which lead to higher production costs and inflation while slowing economic output.

Weak productivity growth, restrictive economic policies, and excessive money supply can also contribute to stagflation. External factors like geopolitical conflicts or global crises may further aggravate the situation.

Stagflation has severe economic consequences, as high inflation erodes purchasing power, making goods and services more expensive, while unemployment reduces consumer spending and weakens overall demand. Businesses face declining profits due to rising costs and lower consumer demand, leading to job losses and economic stagnation.

Addressing stagflation requires a delicate balance of economic policies. While increasing interest rates can help control inflation, it may further slow growth and increase unemployment. On the other hand, stimulus measures to boost employment can worsen inflation. Governments often focus on supply-side solutions, such as increasing productivity, stabilizing energy prices, and ensuring efficient supply chains, to mitigate the effects of stagflation.

Precis:

Stagflation is a challenging economic condition marked by slow growth, high inflation, and rising unemployment. It often results from supply shocks, weak productivity, or external crises, leading to reduced consumer spending and declining business profits.

Traditional policies struggle to address stagflation, as controlling inflation can worsen unemployment, and boosting jobs may fuel inflation. Effective solutions include supply-side measures like improving productivity and stabilizing commodity prices to restore economic balance.

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Best regards,
[Your Name]
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Match the column

1. Wool over the eyes
2. Jump through hoops
3. Up in the air
4. By the book
5. To get down to business

A. to do a complicated things in order to get or achieve something
B. exactly according to the rules
C. to start the work that has to be done
D. unresolved
E. to trick or deceive someone

Answer:

1-e

2-a

3-d

4-b

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Impermissible:
2. Setback:
3. Rescind:
4. Jeopardy:
5. Supplant:
6. Recalibrate:
7. Laudable:
8. Competence:
9. Sagacious:
10. Exacerbate:

1.
Ans: c
Explanation:
Reference: "The view is that institutional preference… is constitutionally permissible; and that admission to UG medical courses can have a residential requirement... However, on the principle that higher qualifications brook no compromise with merit, PG courses should not be open for any such residential preference."

The Supreme Court allows residential preference for UG courses, reasoning that local doctors trained at the UG level are more likely to serve the community. However, PG courses require attracting the best talent, so residential preference is not allowed.

Incorrect Options:

a) The Court permits institutional preference but prohibits residential preference for PG courses.
b) Institutional preference is allowed for PG courses, not just UG.
d) Residential preference is not allowed for PG courses.

2.

Ans: b

Explanation:

Reference: "It is expected that aggrieved States may seek a review of this judgment. It is likely that the verdict will result in the Union government finding one more way to restrict the role of the States in medical admissions."

The passage suggests that States may seek a review of the judgment, fearing that it is part of a broader trend where the Union government restricts the role of States in medical admissions.

Incorrect Options:

a) The ruling focuses on meritocracy, which is intended to improve the quality of education.
c) The passage does not directly discuss regional disparities in healthcare access.
d) There is no evidence in the passage that this ruling will discourage medical students.

3.

Ans: d

Explanation:

Reference: "The solution lies in creating educational infrastructure of near-uniform quality in every district."

The passage suggests that States want to retain local students for PG courses because they have heavily invested in medical education. It argues that the solution lies in creating uniform quality educational infrastructure across districts, so that such preferences become unnecessary.

Incorrect Options:

a) The passage does not criticize private institutions.

b) There is no mention of PG seat shortages in the passage.

c) While it hints at centralization, the focus is on uniform education quality rather than policy-making.

4.

Ans: a

Explanation:

Reference: "There is also concern that Mr. Trump has surrounded himself with acolytes who subscribe to the ideas in the so-called ‘Project 2025’, which some regard as a right-wing agenda that could prove to be more divisive than it is capable of genuinely addressing urgent political priorities."

The passage mentions ‘Project 2025’ and suggests that some view it as a right-wing agenda that could be more divisive than constructive.

Incorrect Options:

b) The passage suggests division, not balance.

c) ‘Project 2025’ is linked to a broader right-wing vision, not just economic reforms.

d) There is no indication of a centrist shift.

5.

Ans: c

Explanation:

Reference: "The ad hoc and apparently uncoordinated approach towards this cut left many, including some Republicans, baffled."

The passage describes the ad hoc and apparently uncoordinated nature of the funding freeze, leading to confusion even among Republicans.

Incorrect Options:

a) The passage does not mention alternative welfare programs.
b) The scale of the cuts was not the issue—rather, it was the uncoordinated execution.
d) There is no reference to corporate tax cuts in the passage.

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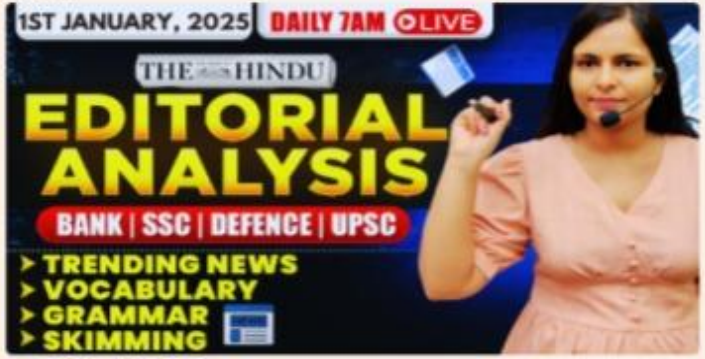

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